CS403BKK Software Engineering

Exam rubric and grading rules

Friday 16 October 2026 | Individual written exam | 180 minutes

Course grading

Component	Weight
Team work	40%
Individual contribution	25%
Individual exam	35%

There is no separate post-block individual analysis submission. Project analysis is included in the exam. The exam assesses your own understanding; individual contribution is assessed separately through attributable course work, informed by self-assessment, peer feedback and instructor observations.

Exam rules

- Work individually under supervision for the full 180-minute writing period.

- Use only the references supplied with the paper. No AI, outside resources, personal notes or communication with others.

- All questions and supplied evidence are available from the start. Submit once at the end.

- Short answers, bullet points, tables and diagrams are welcome. Explain your reasoning; polished English is not required.

- State uncertainty rather than inventing facts. Distinguish actual project outcomes from expectations or unverified claims.

How answers are assessed

The criteria below describe answer quality. They are not separate, equally weighted scoring categories; use the criteria relevant to each question.

Criterion	What a strong answer demonstrates
Understanding	Identifies the relevant problem and applies engineering concepts accurately to the situation.
Reasoning and judgement	Explains why a decision makes sense, including relevant alternatives, trade-offs and limitations.
Evidence and uncertainty	Uses the supplied facts or concrete project examples; separates observations, assumptions and claims that still need checking.
Consequences and verification	Connects decisions to their effects and explains how an outcome or improvement could be checked.

Credit and fairness

- A correct conclusion with a clear explanation earns more credit than the same conclusion without supporting reasoning.

- Relevant, correct reasoning can earn partial credit even when an answer is incomplete. Unsupported assertions and terminology alone do not demonstrate understanding.

- Different conclusions can earn credit when they fit the facts and are justified. A simpler approach or an honest account of incomplete work can be valid.

- Marks reflect understanding and reasoning, not answer length or polished English. Make your meaning clear.

- Feedback about the course is optional and ungraded. It does not affect your mark.

Exam marks and course weighting

Question-level marks will be stated on the final paper; they are not allocated in this overview. Your exam percentage contributes 35% of your overall course grade. For example, an exam result of 80% contributes 28 percentage points to the course total (80% × 35).

Rubrics by exam section

These sections match the exam's subject areas. They describe what is assessed without disclosing the questions. No separate percentage allocation is implied.

Part 1 - Understand the application

- Member journey: connects user actions, application behaviour and stored data; explains how to establish whether the expected outcome occurred.

- Shared language and business rules: uses agreed meanings and rules to evaluate behaviour and justify a change.

Part 2 - Divide the work

- Interfaces: explains how teams agree on their interaction and verify that the connected parts work together.

- Extraction readiness: identifies dependencies and ownership concerns, and justifies changes needed for separate operation.

Part 3 - Work as a team

- Coordination: explains how updates and tracked work make progress, dependencies and next actions clear; distinguishes useful information from vague reporting.

- Responsibilities: explains the consequences of missing ownership and proposes a workable way to restore accountability.

Part 4 - Handle failures

- Incident response: justifies initial priorities and clear coordination in relation to the situation and available evidence.

- Learning from incidents: explains the purpose of root cause analysis and connects its findings to useful follow-up work.

Part 5 - Observe the system

- Measurements: calculates and interprets a service measure correctly, including the limits of what it establishes about a service agreement.

- Investigation: distinguishes technical signals from user outcomes and identifies relevant evidence for checking a reported problem.

Part 6 - Analyse the project experience

- Problem and practice: connects an engineering practice to a concrete need experienced in the project.

- Decisions and alternatives: explains the reasoning, trade-offs and circumstances in which a simpler approach would suffice.

- Outcomes and evidence: compares expectations with observed results, recognising incomplete work and unverified claims.

- AI and verification: evaluates a concrete benefit or failure, explains how output was checked and limits claims to what the evidence supports.

- Next investment: prioritises a justified improvement and explains how its value could be assessed.

Quality across these sections

Strong answers are accurate, specific and reasoned, with relevant evidence or checks. Partially developed answers demonstrate some correct understanding but leave important explanations or connections incomplete. Unsupported or inaccurate answers provide little evidence of understanding. These descriptions guide judgement; they are not additional numerical grade bands.

Course feedback

Optional and ungraded. Feedback is not assessed against the exam rubrics.